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James Moody

James Moody's musical skills and engaging personality have made him one of the great stars of the jazz world. He was born in Savannah, Georgia on May 26, 1925, and was raised in Newark, New Jersey and Reading, Pennsylvania. He took up the saxophone at age 16 and gained valuable playing experience in the Air Force, where he met and played with Dizzy Gillespie. James became a member of Dizzy's Be Bop Orchestra and he enjoyed a long relationship with the trumpet master. His 1949 recording of "Moody's Mood for Love" became a classic and he was covered by vocalists Eddie Jefferson and King Pleasure. James is one of the premier jazz flautists and most of his solo albums include a song featuring his unique vocal style. He has been honored by the Newark, NJ, Jamaica and the International Jazz Hall of Fame organizations. James lives in San Diego with his wife and manager Linda Moody.

James was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 13, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today in San Diego, and it's a great honor for me to have one of the great saxophone players of our day, James Moody. I am thrilled to be talking to you as you are a person that I listened to on the way up playing myself.

JM: Well thank you. It's a pleasure to be here.

MR: You've had quite a career as a leader, as an arranger and composer, and playing with Dizzy. Would you do it all over again?

JM: If I had it to do all over again I would. But a couple of things I'd do differently. I'd go to a music school first.

MR: Interesting that you say that. Why would you do that?

JM: Because it's something that a person that's studying gets quicker — it takes me longer to get to it, you know what I mean. Like when you study and you do it systematically, like they teach you in school, I'm assuming, this is my assumption, that you learn it quicker. Like anything, if it took me four years, like someone else could get it in one year you see? That's what I'm assuming.

MR: Learning the theory and the chord structure and all that kind of thing?

JM: Yeah.

MR: I assume also with arranging perhaps.

JM: Yep. All that.

MR: It could help with that. Jazz has become quite an institution in schools now so there's a lot of places you can go for that.

JM: Well I'll tell you Monk, now maybe up where you're from, mainly because of Chuck Mangione and the people up there like that, and his brother Gap and Nick Brignola and the guys — who was the tenor player from up there, he's a good buddy of mine.

MR: Joe Romano? Sal Nistico?

JM: Sal Nistico, yeah, they were all my buddies. And I think Joe Romano is in Las Vegas now, I think that's where he's living. But anyway, like it seems like the people up there seem to go for jazz a little more than another city. But as far as people, as far as them teaching jazz in the schools, or music for that matter, I think that like it's a sad situation. And I think that it should be in all schools, all colleges. I think jazz should be taught in grammar school. And the reason for that is because when you start learning music, it takes your mind off of things that are really not important, but you think they are important when you're young. And then when you get older then you say why did I feel that way — such as like oh I'm worried about what Mary or Bob or Jane, you worry about what they're thinking. And when you get older you find out that it didn't matter a hill of beans what they thought about you, because they didn't give a damn anyway, because they felt the same way you did maybe.

MR: And they were worried about what you were thinking about them.

JM: Right. And that's one of the reasons why they say it's a shame that youth is wasted on the young. Because like you think oh this is important, oh it's the greatest day of my life, graduation day, oh graduation day, oh the prom, I mean, so what.

MR: I know what you mean. When I talk to my own children who are teenagers now, and some of the things that are so important to them, and you want to say look, ten years from now you're going to chuckle at this. But you can't really say that to them.

JM: No. Because like you're the nut. But then, about ten years from now they're going to say wow, you've gotten smarter.

MR: Right. I wanted to talk for a moment about one of your recent albums, "Moody Plays Mancini," which is — your soprano sound came off just gorgeous on that record.

JM: Oh, well thank you.

MR: And in fact I just wanted to see if I got this up here—

[audio interlude]

MR: Was this fairly spontaneous?

JM: Yeah.

MR: Well it's a gorgeous sound. How did this album come about?

JM: Well the company wanted a concept. And that's the thing nowadays, concept.

MR: Right.

JM: So we came up with the concept. Frank Sinatra before this. And then after this, Mancini, so that was the concept. But that's how that came about.

MR: Does that bother you at all? That you need to do a concept?

JM: Yes it does, I have to be truthful, yes it does. Because you see what I think is that, and it's been like this for a long time, the artist or the musician should make the records, and the record companies should sell them. But it's the other way around. They want to make the records and then they want you to sell them. I mean that's the impression I get.

MR: That the people that hold the purse strings are not musicians—

JM: No, they never are.

MR: They never were.

JM: And here's my saying, and I know my wife, this is — blessed are those that run around in circles, for they shall be called big wheels. And the website, what'd you call that honey, in my website they asked do you have anything to say? And that's what I say. Because if you notice, like the people that don't really know are always telling people like what to do. And that affects the other people like, they say oh well, yeah, like he's not a musician but he's got good ears.

MR: That's a good catch phrase.

JM: Oh, man, yeah. Like so the musician's been playing deaf? Anyway.

MR: Have you had more luck with one label than the other throughout your career? Has there been times when you've said I have to get off this particular label?

JM: Well I've had better luck. I have to say, yeah, with some labels better than others. But you know what I would love to do? I would love to be able to go into the studio with the musicians that I want, and the engineer should be there, and I'd just do what I wanted to do, the way I wanted to do it, and that would be it. Rather than somebody stopping me — hold it, take one more take. I'd like to just be able to do that.

MR: Well it's distressing to hear.

JM: And years ago I did do it.

MR: Years ago you did?

JM: Oh, years ago, with Chess and Checker. I'd go in and like whatever I wanted to do that was it, I just had the stuff and I'd stomp it off and play it and that would be it.

MR: It's almost as if the budgets that they had for those records at those times was probably small, so they said look, get in there, make this record in a day or two, and that's what we can handle.

JM: No, not a day or two, I mean we used to make albums in three hours. Now you make an album in nine years.

MR: And plus you said something that probably was the key to that, and that was you had the people you wanted, and that you knew you could go in and play and get through the project.

JM: Well see the thing is like I'd just like to have some people that I — the people that I talk to and I know like I want, and say hey, I want you to do this, I want you do to this, and this is it. Okay. This is it. Take one, this is the take. That's it. Bamm. See because the first take, like that's it. You know you can play something, you know just to get the sound if you have to, but when you're doing something man, bamm. That's it. No, I think you could do that better. I think you could do that better?

MR: Okay. Well let me take you back a little bit. You're from Georgia originally?

JM: I was born in Savannah. Born, but not raised there. I was raised in Reading, Pennsylvania and Newark, New Jersey.

MR: And how did you come to the saxophone? Was it your first choice of instruments?

JM: I just loved the way it looked, and loved the way it sounded.

MR: Yeah?

JM: Yeah. I told my wife Linda, I told her, "Honey," I says, "in Newark, New Jersey where I lived, around the corner from where I lived, I lived on West Street, and if you went down the block and turned a corner, that was Springfield Avenue, there was a music store there called Dawn & Kirchner. And they used to have these windows, and they were just lined up with saxophones, you know, just lined up. And boy I used to go and just press my nose in it and look at it. Oh, man." And finally one day my uncle bought me, he got me a saxophone, but it didn't look like those, it was silver and it was alto, second hand, you know. But later on I finally got a nice horn. But the first horn I got, when I got it, oh man, I dug it. I put it in the bed next to me and just looked at it. I was out man.

MR: Oh, that's nice, that's nice. I wish we had a photo of that.

JM: Yeah. Sixteen years old.

MR: And that was an alto?

JM: Alto, yeah. And you know what? It must have been a Conn because it had one of those screw things on it. Because I even forgot what — like in those days, I mean it didn't mean anything, Conn or whatever, it was a saxophone.

MR: But it was probably an old, the silver color one?

JM: Yeah.

MR: Were people still playing, were they selling the C melodies back then too?

JM: I don't know, they probably were because I saw some, but the C melody, the C melody, no that wasn't — and then again, I really didn't know either alto or tenor. Like I just wanted a saxophone you see? And then when I went to the theater and saw Lester Young and — no I didn't see Lester Young but I mean I heard him on the records with Count Basie — well first of all, Jimmy Dorsey was my first inspiration, Jimmy Dorsey. So he played alto, so okay, well that could have been one of the reasons why I liked that. Then Charlie Barnet and Georgie Auld, and then I heard — when I heard Georgie Auld man, I

said no I like that better than the others. Then I heard Coleman Hawkins, and Prez. Now when I heard Hawk, he didn't knock me out like Lester Young did. But when I got older, I realized that Hawk was playing the changes better than Lester Young. But Lester Young had that beat and that sound, you know [scats]. Oh I like that boy. And then when I heard Charlie Parker and Dizzy, I said that settles that. That's it. Yep. So that's how that happened. And then I was drafted in the Air Force. And they said, "Does anyone here play an instrument?" No — they said, "Do you have an instrument?" And I said, "Yeah, I've got one." They said, "Send for it." They didn't ask if you could play it, they said if you had it. I said yeah. So I sent for the instrument and they formed a band. And in those days, like it was segregated, and I was stationed in Greensboro, North Carolina. So they had a segregated — like they wanted to have — the base was like, say this is the base like this. This one quarter here was Negro and the other three-quarters was Caucasian, all right? So they wanted a Negro band. So that's what they did, they formed one. And they had the official Air Force Band come over and teach the Negro band. They taught us. And then in about a year or so, man, our band was really nice, it sounded good. So they would come over and listen to our band. And I made some good friends with some of the guys because like even now when I play, one of the clarinet players, he always comes by if he's in town for the gig when I play it. Says, "Hey Moody, remember" so-and-so? Yeah I remember man. I was eighteen years old.

MR: Did your band ever go to play for the white servicemen?

JM: Oh yeah. You played for the officers, oh yeah, you played for them you know, like that. We were down there, I was stationed in Greensboro, and I'm not sure if the Tuskegee Airmen came by there or not, but I remember there was trouble in town one night and it had to do with officers. Because as I was telling about the German prisoners of war jumping off the trucks and going in the restaurants eating in Greensboro, and I couldn't go and eat in the restaurants because I was a Negro you see? So there was some kind of problem in town. And I was wondering if that could have had something to do with the Tuskegee Airmen who were there, because this was an overseas replacement. Before, when I went there, it was BTC # 10. Basic Training Center #10. Then it changed over to ORD. Replacement Depot. Overseas Replacement Depot. And I'm wondering if the Tuskegee Airmen were getting ready to go overseas and that's when they had some of the problems in town, because the racism was rampant.

MR: The process of learning to improvise for you — you must have been getting into it even before you went into the service, is that right?

JM: Reading?

MR: Improvising really. When you heard Lester Young, and you heard Charlie Barnet, and as you said there wasn't schools to do at that time, how did you go about learning how to play jazz?

JM: Listening to records. I'd hear something and then try to play it like I thought maybe it sounded. And that's how I did. And I played by ear for the longest time. And Tom McIntosh is the one that showed me changes you see? And that's why I'll always be indebted to him, man. I was on tour with Brook Benton. The Brook Benton Revue, with Ruth Brown, the Falcons, and the James Moody Orchestra. Okay? This was on the bus. And we get finished playing, I had that septet. I had the "Moody's Mood for Love" thing, so I had the septet and I came back from Europe and we were on tour, and after we get finished playing a gig, like while we were on the road, we'd be down with a blanket over our heads in the back of the bus and he'd be showing me the chords. This is what a chord is, and this and that and everything. Because I remember asking guys, "What's a chord?" And they'd look at me and laugh. They thought I was joking I guess.

MR: So up until that point, even when you recorded "Moody's Mood for Love," it was all coming from your ear.

JM: All by ear. "Moody's Mood for Love," the same thing. What I did was, I was playing tenor, so Lars Gullin, who was a very fantastic baritone jazz player in Sweden — good musicians in Sweden boy, wonderful — he had this beat up looking silver alto sitting by him at the record date. I asked him do you mind if I look at it? He said no. In the old days it was different. You played other people's horns. You know you would never do that now. So anyway, they said you have one more cut to do, what would you like to do? I said how about "I'm in the Mood for Love?" Okay? And they said okay. So Gus Aphalia — this is the truth — the arranger, he went into the john and jotted down the harmonies, and then came back out and put them up on the thing, and we did it in one take. Now here's why it sounded like it sounded. When they hit the chord — boom — [scats]. I'm trying to find the notes, because it's alto now, not tenor. And people said oh you must have been inspired. I said yeah, I'm inspired to try and find the notes, that's what I was inspired.

MR: That's great.

JM: True story, right honey? So and it became a big seller. So then one day I'm in New York, because I wasn't going to come back, I was living in France then, in Paris. I wasn't going to come back because I never will forget I used to write things to my mother and I used to say things like, I shouldn't have said it but that's the way I felt, because in those days, like if you say an ofay cat, that meant a Caucasian person. Ofay. So I'd put "U.S.A. Land of the Ofay." And my mother would say, oh, they'll put you in jail for that. Because I had had it, like with the racism that went on. I mean it was— remember I told you about the

Brook Benton Revue? I'm going to tell them about the donut, honey. We were on the tour, and I forget just where we were, but I had a hundred dollar bill. So I went into the donut shop to get some donuts. They said they didn't have any change. So I went across the street to an automobile company, where they sell automobiles, asked for change, they didn't have it there. So I said oh the heck with it. I got back on the bus. So when I got on the bus, in a minute, Brook Benton called me and says, "Hey, Moody." I said, "What?" He says, "This state trooper wants to see you." So I thought he was joking, a state trooper. I looked out, sure enough there's a state trooper down there. So I get off, and the state trooper looks at me, and he says, "What's your name?" I told him I says, "James Moody." He says, "What do you do?" I said, "Well see, my name's on the bus there," I said "I'm with the band here." And Brook says, "Maybe —" he says "get the hell out of here, get over here, I'm not talking to you, I'm talking to him." So he says, "How much money do you have?" I says, "I don't know, maybe four or five hundred dollars." So he says, "Let me see it." So I reached in one pocket and pulled out my traveler's checks. And in another pocket I had cash, but something told me don't do it. So I gave him the traveler's checks, about seven, eight hundred bucks in traveler's checks, because I had to pay the band. And so he looks at the traveler's checks, he looks at me and he says, "Too much money." So what am I supposed to say to the guy? Too much money? I mean I didn't say anything. He looked again, "Too much money." I said, "Well," I says, "I'm the leader here," and I said, "and I have to pay the musicians. I haven't paid them all." He says, "Too much money." So he put it down and he looked at me again. "Too much," he must have said this about fifteen or twenty times, then he called for another car, and another car came with a lieutenant, and they talked, and then a captain came and they talked. After this crap went on about a half hour, forty-five minutes, they came over again and did it again. "Too much money — too much money." And then I mean he just gave me the traveler's checks back and he left. Now you know what happened? When I went in to the automobile store, evidently they said there's a Negro over here with a hundred dollar bill, he probably stole it. So the cops came, and that's how that came about.

MR: That's distressing to hear. In fact, Ruth Brown told us a story about how she got pulled over and all the musicians were in the car and they had to get out and play on the side of the road to prove — because they had a Cadillac or something.

JM: Well I was on the bus when we were doing a tour with Ella Fitzgerald and we were late for the gig, about two hours late, and we pulled up to the place, like I mean everybody had gone and all like that. And the guy pointed to Ella Fitzgerald, she had her hair all wrapped up in her thing, and she wasn't feeling well, tired, and the owner of the place wanted her to sing for his wife. I mean we finally got out of it, but I mean he wanted her to sing.

MR: Did things get better in the 60s with the Civil Rights movement and all that? Did it get better?

JM: They were going good. They were going all right. They seemed to be going good because people seemed to be sensitive to these things, and the morale of people seemed to be picked up a little bit, and the Caucasian people seemed to have a feeling that wow, boy, that's a drag. And then Reagan became president, and he messed everything up again and set it back fifty years. That thing hurt me when they named that airport after him, after he fired all those air controllers, now they're going to name an airport after him? For what? What did he do? Trickle down. Trickle down. How about trickling up? You know yeah, the money will go to the big businesses and then it'll trickle down and then you'll have it later. Never mind, money should trickle up. Let the little people get it and give it to the big businesses. But I mean I didn't want him to get shot, you know, I don't want any harm to come to him that way, but I could do without him man. I mean he was a sad-ass president, that's the only way to explain it. And so was Bush.

MR: I take it you're not a Republican.

JM: No, I'm not a Republican. And you know it was nice, I was on a plane one time going somewhere and a guy gave me the space for my saxophone and I put it up top. And then somebody said something to me, and I said oh, no, so-and-so-and Reagan so-and-so, and I said the whole Republican thing and the guy says, "What?" He says, "Give me my spot back." But he was joking, but it was nice.

MR: Oh, boy. Tell me about, we had just gotten up to where you heard Dizzy and Charlie Parker. You said that's it.

JM: Yeah.

MR: So you got into bop. Did you find that music to be more of a challenge to play?

JM: Let me put it to you this way. If you don't know anything about something and you're just doing it, and then people start explaining to you, like this or that is hard, you know what I mean?

MR: Right.

JM: I was in Las Vegas and I was playing this clarinet part, and I'm playing it. And the lead alto player looks over at me and looks at the part and he says, "Oh man," he says, "I'm glad that's not on my part," and the next fill, I missed it, see? Because that's what happens if you let that happen.

MR: He pointed out to you that that was really hard.

JM: Yeah. See but for me, I always tell students there's no such thing as difficulty, there's nothing ever hard, what you have to do is familiarize yourself with it. That's what I tell our boys. I say familiarization is the key to everything. When you familiarize yourself with it, you've got it. And then I go into a thing. Like I say well — say meow.

MR: Meow.

JM: Now put a B on that.

MR: B Meow.

JM: No. Put a B where the M is.

MR: Beow.

JM: Right. Okay, that's a nice sound right?

MR: Right.

JM: Beow good. Anyway, so I told my son Danny and them that, and then they say oh, okay. And then finally I say — do you speak Chinese?

MR: I can say ni hao.

JM: Ni hao. Is that Wong how. Good. Yeah. Good for us, right honey? Okay. How do you say watch in Chinese.

MR: That I don't know.

JM: See that's my thing see? So I say if you're familiar with it, you've got it. You said it just before.

MR: Ah. Beow.

JM: Beow, yeah that's right. See what I mean? Now you're familiar with it.

MR: All right. I probably won't forget that either.

JM: No, see, because I set you up.

MR: Chi-chi — I think is thank you, isn't it?

JM: But you see what I'm saying though? And like if a kid sees something, and you show it to him, and he can do it slowly, and — oh, I see that. It's simple. They call it the light bulb going on. And I always say this, like I've been kind of fortunate, because if I explain something to you this way and you don't get it, I can explain it four, five, six different other ways, like I think I can, because I've been pretty fortunate I've been able to do that. Because I hate for someone to come to me for someone, and I'm trying to show them, and they don't get anything out of it. But, like you said about the bebop thing, people said well how did you feel playing bebop when you joined Dizzy's band? When I joined Dizzy's band in '46 it was I think, Monk was the piano player, Thelonious Monk, and Kenny Clarke was the drummer, Ray Brown bass, Milton Jackson vibraharp and Mr. Howard Johnson, lead alto, and Sol was the baritone player and then later Cecil Payne came in. Ernie Henry and then later John Brown, Dave Burns, Miles was in the band, Fats Navarro. I mean but I was young. I didn't — hey man, I was there — I thought I was going to sneeze, I think I will, hold it one moment — all this is cool, no it goes along with it.

MR: That's right. This is live.

JM: [Sneezes] Thank you, honey. So I didn't realize it. And I tell people if I would have known I probably would have fainted. And it's better that I didn't realize. But it was really interesting to know things, and I came right in the club and played the music, and I mean everything was fine.

MR: Where did most of those arrangements come from for that?

JM: Gil Fuller. Walter Fuller. Walter Fuller did the arrangements and then after a while I think Gerald Wilson did a couple of things. I never will forget because Gerald Wilson did something, and this chord kept coming up. I said, "Diz" I said, "hey man, that's wrong, that's wrong, man, that note's wrong." And he just said, "Moody, be quiet, shut up, Jesus, be quiet." Come to find out it was a flat five. Hey, man. But I look back now and people ask me they say well how did it feel being with Dizzy, what did you learn from him and how was it working for him. And I tell them I says man, like every day, like something pops up and I say that's what he meant. You see what I mean? And like I could be on a plane in Europe somewhere, ah, okay, or a piece of music and I say mmmm. You know what I mean? My honey, she's heard that a lot of times. Because there where I'll say oh, okay. And you know what? When Dizzy passed, I was calling home, and my wife wouldn't answer the phone, okay? And then I says, "Honey," I says, "man I called you, it was 569-4875." And she says, "Honey, that's Dizzy's number." I would be calling his number, thinking I was calling her.

MR: Was that band, was it a struggle to keep it solvent?

JM: Well I would assume that it probably was. Because one of the — the 2040 Seventh Avenue, that address, I think that was it, and Dizzy and Lorraine's apartment was like, it was okay, it was furnished. But the guy that worked for Dizzy, the one that he hired, Carpenter, his apartment was great, these plush rugs, and I said, wait a minute — this is the other way around. Anyway like later on they found out. And I said now how stupid can you be, because he lived on the first floor, and — so what's the matter, we're not partners anymore? You know one for you, two for me, one for you, three for me, one for you, four for me. Okay.

MR: Well when you were in Europe, you considered staying you said. You considered staying in Europe. But you didn't.

JM: No.

MR: You eventually came back, and why did you decide?

JM: Well I came because the record was a hit, and they kind of convinced me, they said go over there and make some money and then come back. I says okay, that's what I did. Then when I got over here I says it's ridiculous for me to run away from the place where I'm born, I'm raised, I have every right to be here, more so than some other people. So why should I — so I stayed.

MR: Did you avoid certain parts of the country when you had your own group?

JM: No I played everywhere. I played Jackson, Mississippi, Alabama, Georgia, I mean yeah. But you know what? I like southerners. And the reason I like the southerners is because a southerner will tell you, I don't want to be bothered with your breezy behind, get the hell out of here. Or either, I love you. And whichever one he says, you can rest assured it's true. But the New Yorker, oh, what a wonderful person, oh man, and stab you in the back, see what I mean?

MR: So you never know what to expect.

JM: Yeah. But when you get my age, I'll be 73 next month, you can kind of smell it and feel it, and you can put on a thing and smile and they think they got you, but you know what's going on. And I do. I can smell it a mile away.

MR: Wow. And it's still around then?

JM: Of course it's around, sure. But you know what's bad about it? The thing is is for a person to think that they're better than someone else, to think that they're different from someone else, when in essence, like if you look at anyone, look at the similarity. I mean all the similarity. The only so-called difference is their pigmentation, their hue. And the reason for that is because of the different climate. And if anybody thinks that I don't know what I'm talking about, like I dare them to read a book called *The 12th Planet*.

MR: I'll have to look that one up.

JM: Yeah. It's by Zecharia Sitchin — S-I-T-C-H-I-N. It has to do with people coming from other planets. And, the gentleman who wrote it, like when he makes a statement, he shows you the writings and the Sumerian texts and things that substantiates what he says you see? The earth revolves 365 days of the year, the planet that these people come from, 3600 years revolve. That's one year for them. So imagine that life span. So they were considered gods. And they, the Nephilims were the ones that created us. And the Anunnakis. Now, the hip thing about the book is he said if the Nephilims created us, who created the Nephilims? I mean we know there's something great but — because when I was a kid, I used to say boy wouldn't it be strange, just like you're stepping on these ants, if a big foot would come down and step on us. You know?

MR: There was a "Twilight Zone" episode about that.

JM: Yeah. But I didn't see that. I didn't know. Yeah. I didn't see that. But you know when you think about things, and then, check this out. In the configuration of where all the planets are, around the sun okay, all the planets are there in the world, NASA is there. Now, six thousand years ago, Galileo and Leonardo DaVinci, they didn't know anything about Pluto, Neptune, Uranus, they didn't know. But the Sumerian did six thousand years ago. And in their thing, the little stone figure carvings, you see the same configuration as NASA, but there's one more planet that, that's the twelfth planet. That's the one that

comes every 3,600 years, and when it comes, what happens? And so they're waiting to see what's going to happen the next time. Now the flood, when it happened, like it wasn't something that happened because the gods were angry. I mean man was destroyed because the gods were angry at man because man was a drag, but they knew that the flood was coming because of the configuration of certain planets, certain things happened, the ice melts, and all that. But I'm telling you, this book — he wrote, it's called *The Earth Chronicles,* and I think six books, five books. And *The 12th Planet* is one of the books. The hip thing about it — I've got the hardback cover because you can just read one chapter, like when man first came to earth or different things, how different things happened. And when you read it, you will not think the same anymore. Now people think well we're talking about music? What has this got to do with music? Everything. Because the Anunnaki is the one that introduced music to the humans, so-called, the homo sapiens. So I mean there's a whole lot happening.

MR: Wow. How did you come across this?

JM: Well there's a friend of mine who was the provost at the University of Pittsburgh. And he's a very good friend of Dr. Nathan Davis, who is the head of the jazz studies, this was Dr. Donald Henderson. And he and his wife, I mean he's retired now, oh he told me some stories about being a provost, I mean racism boy — like he was supposed to send a picture with his resume because he was accepted at five different colleges. He didn't send a picture and he was accepted at every one. And when he came to Pittsburgh, because that's the one he chose, they said if you would have sent the picture you wouldn't have gotten this job. Then they set him up and had a chick come by. They say oh, like, he didn't go for it. But he says no, he says, my first thing is to my wife, and the next is to the university, I don't do it, that's not my style. Anyway, but he's retired now, so he goes and he does space things. So when they have space things out in Mexico and things, his wife, they go to these things. Flying saucers. And he introduced me to those books. Now this man is nobody's fool. And like I'm not dumb, like you can't pull the wool over my eyes but so far, but I mean for me to read these things, I mean, believe me Monk, there's something to it. There's something to it. And all this is applicable. Because I tell students, when you're playing music, like no matter what it is you do, I don't care what it is, everything is applicable to everything else. It all goes together. It does. Because like if I practice and play music, I play, play, play, play. When I get finished my relaxation is to read or to go spiritually. I want to go. Now last night my wife and I we looked at the T.V. and Swaggart was on T.V.

MR: Oh, the preacher.

JM: And I was sitting there, and people got their arms raised and said, "Oh Jesus — Oh Jesus — Oh yes — Oh Jesus we love you Jesus, oh Jesus, Lord, Lord Jesus you're wonderful."

For 45 minutes that's all he said. Now, suppose I take my saxophone and say, "Oh my saxophone, oh my saxophone, oh it's wonderful, it's wonderful, my wonderful saxophone," I mean it gets very boring. And not only that but like I haven't said anything you know. And that's what wrong. And it's said, the synagogue, the Baptist church, the Methodist, the Episcopalian, all these churches have failed the people. You know why? Because they don't say anything. They tell you what the Bible says. The Bible doesn't say anything. Have you ever heard the Bible say something? You see what I mean? Jesus? How can Jesus be the son of God and then all of a sudden he's going to be God? You see? My wife and I, we're Bahai. We believe in all of the prophets. If the Americans are so stupid as to think that Jesus is the only prophet, I mean it's ridiculous. Because if that were the case then that means that God loves the Chinese people better than we did because their prophet he made over a billion and a half people over there. I mean a billion and a half of them. Right? And we know I mean that's not so. But music goes with all of that. All of that. And the reason is because when we didn't have anything else to say about, oh I love you Jesus, then I go [sings] Oh Jesus, he is the one, he told us he's a — So I mean, oh, man.

MR: Dizzy also practiced the Bahai.

JM: Dizzy was a Bahai, yes. But he didn't tell me anything about it. After he passed, my wife and I we became Bahais — because we would go to the chapel where we went, and for that very same reason the minister would be talking about, and Jesus said do good, and Jesus said do this, and he said be good and don't do this. But he wouldn't really say what should be said. Like you shouldn't like hate a person and you shouldn't teach your children to hate because you think that this is that and whatever. No they didn't do that. Oh and another thing, in all the schools see, now they come up with that race thing about jazz. I was in France and the French were saying oh yes, well you know that the Negro plays jazz better than the Caucasian man. That isn't true. It's not true. Because all people are the same. And if you've got the ability, and you hear the music, and you like it, and you study it, you can play it. You can't play a record and tell me who's playing. You can't play a record and tell me what color anyone is. Just like you can't take some blood and tell me what color someone is. So I mean there are so many discrepancies in the world and the way people think. People think that if I look a certain way I'm better than you automatically. Stupid.

MR: Sounds like you ought to write a book, to me.

JM: Well a book is being written about me, by Nathan Davis' wife, Dr. Ursula Davis. She's writing a book about my life supposedly. But you know what I like? I would really like for people, like sometimes when you put it like in so-called black and white, people still don't want to see what you know— I guess the actions speak louder than words. But jazz

is a wonderful music as far as I'm concerned, and I hate all these different smooth jazz, sweet jazz, bittersweet jazz, fast jazz, slow jazz.

MR: All the labels that they put on.

JM: Yeah that they're putting out there. Jazz is jazz. Bang. Music. You hear it and either you like it you don't. Now, when I don't like something, if I tell you I don't like that, okay? You ask me anything you want about it, and if I can't answer those questions, I don't have a license to dislike it. You know what I mean?

MR: Sure.

JM: But if I dislike something, and you say well why don't you like it, and my answer is, "Because," that's pretty stupid, isn't it?

MR: That's one thing that some programs I've worked in the public schools that we try to do, is to get the kids to be able to make judgments about things so that they simply don't say I don't like that at all, and to get them to be able to discern why. It's a struggle sometimes, but exactly what you're saying.

JM: Well check this out, Monk, if I play — do you know something, like, take something that you really hate, you can't stand musically, and you have to do something, and you put it on and it plays over and over again. You know what your mind will do? Your mind, especially you being a musician, your mind will find something in that thing to like, to grow with. Okay? And what's happening, like my saying that I say — blessed are those that run around in circles, for they shall be called big wheels — these people at the radio stations, they don't know their butts from holes in the ground. And those are the people that are choosing the music to play for people. If I give you something that I think you'll want, I haven't given you anything. But if I give you something that I know is good, and I feel that it can help you grow spiritually or something, and I give you that, I've given you something. When I play for a person, I don't play for you. I play for me. And the reason I play for me is because I want to play better today, and I want to play better tomorrow than I did today. By that I'm saying I want to grow, musically and spiritually. So when I'm playing for you, I'm giving you honesty. But if I see you and I figure you want to hear me moan and whoa — and scream, because that'll get you, I'm being dishonest. And for me, that isn't music see? Music consists of three things: melody, harmony and rhythm. One thing alone doesn't make music okay? So all that other stuff that they play on the radio for people, because they think it makes big bucks, yeah, but you know what? It makes big bucks but you watch, it's also tearing down the moral fiber of youthfulness. I mean in other words the young kids are being like smothered with — excuse me, the only way I could — with bullshit. And you know that saying, if you can't dazzle them with brilliance, baffle them with bullshit. You've heard that saying. Well that's what's happening today. Not only musically, but every which way.

MR: Across the board in entertainment.

JM: In medicine, in every which way. Because first of all, look at Oprah. Any time a person can't say well oh yeah, wow, well I'll be damned. Beef is that bad? Well you know what? I think I'll never eat another hamburger again. That's because she has a show and somebody — because look, twenty million people calling a television set an automobile doesn't make it one. But, if something is good for you, and you like it, I don't care what somebody says about it, I'm going to still do it, see? So like if beef is all that good for you, people are going to eat it, but because Oprah said she didn't want to eat a hamburger, they're suing her for ten million dollars. In Texas you see. And if you notice, anything that's really good, if you notice the good stuff is not there. Musically or any other way. You ever notice that? I mean the guys that could really play — I always say the greatest are yet to be heard. You know because the guys that play their buns off man, you don't hear them that much. Look at Jerry Bergonzi.

MR: Who? Sorry.

JM: Jerry Bergonzi. Oh man, isn't he bad? But hear him man, boy I mean he's playing some stuff, you know what I mean? I look at — oh thank you very much — look at Diz. Like people want to forget about him like he never existed. But —

MR: Do you think there's too much emphasis on something has to be new?

JM: But that's just the point, there isn't anything new. Everything is the same, only it's — I know what it is there's no air in here — only it's turned another way you see? Because when you get up, no matter what it is, it's different. If I play a C scale today, it's going to be different from tomorrow, even though to me it sounds as if it's the same, but it's different. And the reason it's different is because first of all look at it. One trillion billionth of an inch — I mean it's damn near nothing okay? But if you're playing music, and now my point I'm trying to make here is — what was the point I had there? What was I saying?

MR: We were talking about new. If things were new, the C scale?

JM: Okay, right, that's it. If I'm playing a scale today, if I play scale now [scats], I'll tell you what, hello.

MR: Hello.

JM: Okay, good. We say that everyday almost, don't we? And you know what? It's never the same. Ever. Because when you say hello, that's that. Now hello — it's not the same. And you know the reason it isn't the same? Because it's a billionth of a second older. And it's different. And I don't care what it is, everything is like that. You see so when people say oh I want something new, and people say there's nothing new under the sun, I'm inclined to agree with that. There's nothing new. I mean it's all here. We just don't know where it is. And just like when Diz said with the music, like man I don't care what the music is,

it's there. All you've got to do is get it. It's there. And once you play it, it's gone. But a thousand, or maybe two thousand, three thousand years from now, they'll be able to turn on a little machine and pick up the sound from when you were a baby, when you were first born, when you came from your mother's womb, and the sound will be able to be like a fingerprint, they'll be able to get you. You mark my words. That's going to happen.

MR: That's some heavy stuff.

JM: Yeah but that's what wrong. People think it's heavy, but that's some light stuff compared to the Nephilims and the Anunnakis. And just imagine the people that created the Nephilims, how heavy that must be you see. So man needs to get up off his behind and quit hating someone, and start thinking about what the truth really is, and leave Clinton alone.

MR: Does this, your philosophies about this thing, does it find its way into your music?

JM: Of course. Because first of all, tell me, like you can't do anything, no matter what it is, anything you do, whatever it is you do — like now, you're sitting here talking to me. You have children at home, right? Okay. And a wife. You can't tell me that while we're talking here something fleeting didn't go through your mind about — you see what I mean? And that happens with everybody. So that's why I say no matter what it is, everything is applicable to everything else. Everything is entwined. And it would be nice if it could all be love. But when you put hate in there, you see? And all that has to do with music. And you can tell some people say [scats] okay that might sound like they're angry, but no not necessarily. Some person could say [scats] and really be pissed off. But you know what? You could still get it, after a while you can stick up for him. Or they say speak softly and carry a big stick. But I'll tell you, the thing that would really help the world would be love. But the thing is, people don't love themselves. And I tell people I'm crazy about me, bald head and all. I love me, mainly because what my mother was, and the way she brought me up. And when I look at that, and then I look at other people, there's no one on this earth anywhere better than me. I don't care, nobody. But by the same token, I'm not better than anyone else. You see? That's the way I feel. I see people and they come up and need a certain thing — why yes, yeah, I say okay, yeah, good. But inside I know, they're cool. And they can kind of pick up that I really don't give a crap. You know what I mean? And you ain't pulling the wool over these eyes. I mean maybe you might, but you're not going to. You know what I mean?

MR: That's a very healthy attitude.

JM: Right. And music soothes the savage beast, and music is truthful. And I'm telling you, I've told a lot of lies to music, and music has looked at me and said no you don't. And there's people, there's proof of it on my records, a lot of them boy.

MR: Yeah?

JM: Yeah, man. I try to do something there and they come and say let's blip this out. And I'm the kind of guy that if I make a mistake, leave it on the record. That's me. Leave it there.

MR: Do you listen to your own music much?

JM: No. No. No. Because I always figure the next one I can do better. When I hear something I've done I say damn, wow, I did that? I didn't realize that. All right. Damn. I didn't remember I could play that.

MR: You and Dizzy were quite an exuberant couple on stage I'd have to say. Did that kind of interplay come natural to you too?

JM: Well to be honest, yeah. Because if you say something funny, I mean you'll make me laugh. It's like this joke I've told, it's a cute joke. And it's about the two burglers robbing this home and they snuck in this home and they heard a voice and the voice said, "Jesus sees your lying behind. Jesus sees you." And they look and they say, "Oh it's only a parrot." And the parrot says, "Yeah, but Jesus is a doberman." That's cute I think, huh honey? Can I get a Kleenex? But Diz man, I'd be playing we'd be on the bandstand, and Dizzy would come up and whisper in my ear "Moody your fly's open," and man I'd be very — and then he'd look at me with that look you know.

MR: He'd do his look to you?

JM: Yeah. Dizzy boy [blows nose]—

MR: Well Bill Crow, you've probably read Bill Crow's book?

JM: Some of it, yeah.

MR: *Jazz Anecdotes*. He had a story about how you guys used to, after you played the head together, something about you'd kind of bump into each other like, who's going to do the solo first?

JM: Oh, that stuff, yeah.

MR: Well it helps to put the music across with a certain amount of exuberance.

JM: Well I guess it wasn't so much put in the music of course, I guess it's making the people relax. Because the music is the same, you see what I mean? It's like a guy say I'm going to go to dinner and to eat but you're sleepy. So you go get some sleep, then you go to dinner. I mean the dinner is the same but you feel better about it, don't you? Well I guess that's the same way Dizzy felt. Because I always called him Dizzy like a fox. He liked people.

MR: What brought you to San Diego?

JM: My wife, Linda. The first time I came I came to Lario's the club where I was playing. And the next time I came I came for Linda McGowan.

MR: To stay.

JM: And now she's Linda Moody.

MR: All right. And how long have you been married?

JM: Nine years April the third. We were. And when I left here after playing the two weeks I was here, I was in love when I left, and I didn't want her to forget me so I had them send her a dozen roses every Monday, see? So I went on tour with Dizzy to Africa, that's when we went — was it a month, honey? Month and a half? That's all? Anyway my phone bill was twelve hundred bucks a week.

MR: I was going to say—

JM: And they made Dizzy a bashir, a chief, in Africa. It was funny. Because we're sitting and the tribe is out there and the chief is sitting up on the thing, and so Dizzy gets this hat you know, the bashir and all like that you know, and then I look and he's slipped the chief a bottle of Gordon gin because the chief liked that. And the chief put his bottle and took a little swig, man, you should have seen the smile on his face. And you know we had to fly on two chartered planes. They were from Gulf Oil. Because the planes over there, man. But that was a hell of an experience boy.

MR: It was an adventure, huh?

JM: Oh man, yeah.

MR: Where else have you played around the world? You've probably been to Japan a number of times?

JM: Oh yeah. Everywhere except India. Who would want to go to India, and mainland China, yeah mainland China, who wants to go there? But people are the same all over the world, no matter where you go, they are the same. And people want the same thing. Like they want to be able to make a living, they want to live decently, and they want to take care of their family. And we went to the Island of Gordé.

MR: Where?

JM: G-O-R-D- with the thing over the E, the hyphen over the E? That's where the slaves shipped off from? Gordé? Boy that was an experience to see that. You know, see that man. But being with Diz was wonderful, because you'd go places, we'd be in Yugoslavia, Czechoslovakia, I mean at the time, and Hungary. You know in Hungary, you know Buda and Pest are two separate places?

MR: Buda and Pest are two separate—

JM: Did you know that, like Budapest? In Hungary, Budapest, Buda is on this side of the bridge, and on the other side is Pest. It's two different places, called Budapest.

MR: I'll be darned.

JM: But going to all those places, that was funny when Diz passed, and I went back to these places, it was really sad, because every place that I had ever gone, the first time I went I went with Dizzy. Japan, Australia, China. The first time I went was with Diz. And then to go and he's not there now, that was kind of heart wrenching a little bit.

MR: Yeah. Did you share his love of Latin music?

JM: Well I have to be honest with you — pardon me — I like [scats] that will get in my ears. But I learned to like it more and more as I did it. So I like it because I've been on tour with Tito Puente, and I mean it's there boy, underneath, it really knocks me out.

MR: Did it take you a while to get used to the — as you were saying the da-goomph? Like they don't usually put the bass notes where we've learned to expect them, at least in my ears. And to me I think that would be the part that I would have the most trouble getting, internalizing.

JM: No it doesn't bother me 'cause I listen to the overall thing [scats], you know, as they say, go with the flow. So yeah I can kind of do that, you know, go with the flow until I get my own flow, then I go—

MR: Well you've got a growing list of recognitions here. The International Jazz Hall of Fame and Newark Hall of Fame, and the NEA Jazz Masters. So it's nice to see that your career is being recognized.

JM: Yeah it's nice. I told my wife it was really nice — she came to me and she had tears in her eyes and she showed me this thing and it said that I was nominated. It's nice to be nominated by your peers. I appreciate that. But I feel that I'm lucky, like very lucky, because I don't say this in a derogatory way or a bad way, but like you take sperm? Like man I don't know how many millions of sperm cells there are there. And like so even to be born we're lucky. So for me to get that, I feel the same way, I was lucky.

MR: Yeah?

JM: Yeah.

MR: What's in the future, the near future for you?

JM: I want to make my wife very, very, very happy. Yep. Make my honey happy. Because it took me 64 years to be found. And like it just seems like it just gets better. And she understands what I try to do, like if I want to practice or something, she says honey don't forget, practice, go do that. And she didn't ask me to get a day job you know or nothing like that. So like I just feel fortunate.

MR: That's cool. You're a romantic. Your romance comes out in the music too.

JM: And she still gets the roses too.

MR: Yeah.

JM: Yeah, every Monday.

MR: I'll be darned. Well that's great. It's been real insightful talking to you.

JM: Well thank you, Monk.

MR: And I'm going to have to read through this, and maybe get that book and check it out.

JM: Yeah. It's really something to check out, I'm telling you. *The 12th Planet*.

MR: Yeah.

JM: I've been saying this. I said it at the club at the Iridium when I was there. I told the people, get that book, man. Just read it.

MR: Do you like going to New York to play?

JM: Oh yeah, all the time. My wife and I, we're crazy about New York. Yeah, boy. Go to New York and get energized, come back here and lose it, and then go back.

MR: It does have an atmosphere.

JM: Oh yeah.

MR: You've got to charge up your batteries to keep up with it.

JM: Yeah, man. And you know there are good musicians here you know, but they don't support it man. Like you have your Holly Hofmann, wonderful flautist here, wonderful, and Charles McPherson, he lives here, Daniel Jackson, he's here. Who's the piano player, honey, and the bass player that used to work at Lario's? Bob Magnusson, and Holly's piano player.

MR: Mike Wofford.

JM: Mike Wofford. There's a lot of good musicians here. But the people don't, they don't seem to support it. But you put that rock crap in there, and then man — and it's funny, because people look at other people and call them savages, and then have they ever seen themselves when you put that [scats] oh my goodness. Ridiculous. But what did Buddy Rich say? Rock music is played by morons for imbeciles or something like that.

MR: It sounds like Buddy.

JM: But I think that good rock is played by good musicians. Because all music can be good if it's played right, but just for someone to know two chords in root position and play, that's kind of, you know. And that's what bugs me, because here I am like 73 years old, and man I'm trying to find out, just learn this and learn that. And you hear something [scats] and people just — "oh isn't that wonderful." I say oh, man. You know like it's an insult really.

MR: I have a pet peeve about standing ovations. People just seem to — they're not discerning enough in some cases. They don't recognize real talent perhaps. But that's another issue.

JM: But you know what? And then in all this screaming. Why would someone — look at Take Six. You've heard Take Six right? When do you hear them? How often do you hear them? See what I mean. And you take a melody like [scats] I mean why would you want to scream over that? Man. The melody is beautiful. And then when you scream, scream light. But you see they're screaming in the wrong places. Anyway.

MR: Well it's been a great pleasure.

JM: Well thank you, Monk.

MR: James Moody, saxophonist and philosopher, and vocalist too.

JM: I don't know about that. But musicians, you know people always say why do musicians think they can sing? Well I'm not a balladeer. But at least I can say [scats] You know what I mean? I can hum my intervals and sing. So that's why I think I can [scats]. You know what I mean. Here's one [scats]. You know that one, right? Put a fourth on there. [scats]

MR: Man I've got to take this tape home now and have a saxophone lesson.

JM: I don't know about that.

MR: Well follow those intervals. All right. Well thanks so much for your time. I hope you keep us informed when you come out east.

JM: Can I get a hug? Thanks, Monk.

MR: Thank you. All right.

JM: Okay.